

Illocutionary Force in (and out of) Syntax: Evidence from Korean Negative Imperatives

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Background The representation of imperatives at the syntax-semantics-pragmatics interfaces remains a matter of long-standing debate in the literature (see von Stechow & Iatridou 2017, and references therein). Although the canonical function of imperatives is to issue commands, “weak” uses like wishes (1) and acquiescence (2) support a minimal semantics (Portner 2007).

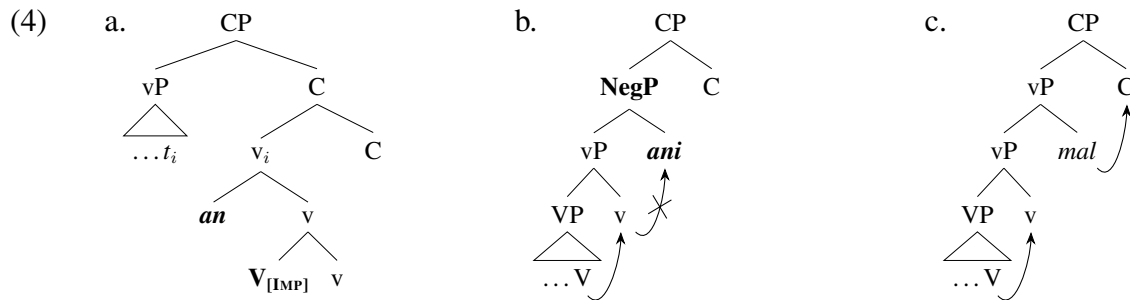
- (1) Please, don’t rain!
- (2) A: It’s getting warm. Can I open the window?
B: Sure. Go ahead. Open it!

Another robust cross-linguistic generalization about imperatives is their incompatibility with negation. While Han (2001) and Zeijlstra (2013) provide straightforward explanations, their analyses crucially rely on the syntactic presence of a force operator. The two views seem at odds: “minimal” theories fail to capture the rarity of Negative Imperatives (NIs), whereas “rich” theories leave (1) and (2) unexplained. We argue that this conflict can be resolved if syntax provides a projection for illocutionary force above the projection encoding sentence type (Portner et al. 2019, Miyagawa 2022, among others). Empirical support comes from Korean NIs.

Korean NIs Korean has two types of negation: short form *an*, which immediately precedes the verb, and long form *ani*, which follows the verb and requires do-support. The former is typically analyzed as a left adjunct to vP that later cliticizes to v, and the latter as a head that projects NegP (Han & Lee 2007). Crucially, however, Korean NIs cannot be formed with either *an* or *ani*. Instead, they require a special form, *mal*.

- (3) a. *Pap-ul *an* mek-ela!
 rice-ACC NEG eat-IMP
 b. *Pap-ul mek-ci *ani* ha-yela!
 rice-ACC eat-CI NEG do-IMP
 c. Pap-ul mek-ci *mal*-ala!
 rice-ACC eat-CI MAL-IMP
 ‘Don’t eat rice!’

Han (2001) posits two requirements: (i) an interpretational requirement that the force operator — realized by the [IMP] feature on the verb — not be c-commanded by Neg, and (ii) a syntactic requirement that the verb move to C in imperatives. The first captures the ungrammaticality of NIs when negation surfaces as a clitic attaching to the verb, and the second accounts for cases where Neg⁰ intervenes; see (4a) and (4b), respectively. On the other hand, (3c) is grammatical because *mal*, an auxiliary verb akin to ‘stop’ (cf. Park 2010), moves to C — an instance of Relativized Minimality (RM) (Rizzi 1990) — and is not c-commanded by Neg; see (4c).

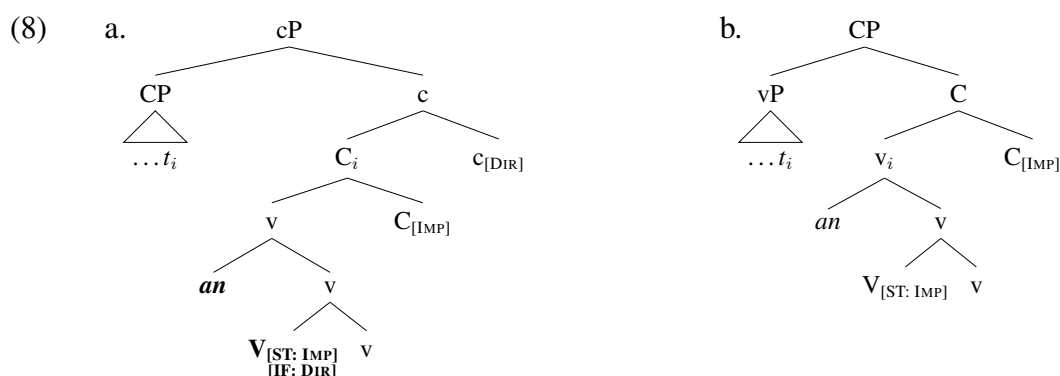


We now present a novel set of data that, to our knowledge, has not yet been observed in the literature: in “weak” NIs, *an* is exceptionally grammatical. Wishes (5), sarcasm (6), and acquiescence (7B) are “weak” in the sense that they do not seem to impose any obligation.

- (5) A, nayil ceypal pi *an* wa-la.
ah tomorrow please rain NEG come-IMP
‘Ah, please don’t rain tomorrow.’

- (6) *Context:* sarcastic remark by a mother to a child who refuses to eat
 Ne kulehkey kyeysok pap *an* mek-ela.
 you like.that continuously rice NEG eat-IMP
 ‘Yeah, keep not eating, sure, that’ll work.’
- (7) A: Ce pap *an* mek-eto.tway-yo? B: ?Kulay, *an* mek-ela.
 I rice NEG eat-can-POL okay NEG eat-IMP
 ‘Is it okay if I don’t eat rice?’ ‘Okay, don’t eat it.’

Analysis We adopt Portner et al.’s (2019) CP–cP system for the syntactic projections of sentence type and illocutionary force. (Hereafter, IMPerative refers to sentence type and DIRECTive to illocutionary force.) Following Portner et al. (2019), with minor revisions discussed below, we assume that “strong” imperatives have both CP and cP, whereas “weak” imperatives lack cP. We further assume that both $C_{[ST: IMP]}$ and $c_{[IF: DIR]}$ value the relevant features on the verb and attract it, so that the imperative verb appears at the topmost position of the syntactic structure.



The syntactic structures of “strong” and “weak” imperatives with *an* are shown in (8a) and (8b), respectively. In “strong” imperatives, the verb — valued with both [ST: IMP] and [IF: DIR] — is c-commanded by Neg, yielding ungrammaticality. By contrast, “weak” imperatives lack the cP layer, so the verb bears no illocutionary force features, which accounts for the exceptional grammaticality of (5-7B). Importantly, the reasoning behind the (un)grammaticality of *ani* (blocking head movement) and *mal* (RM) remains the same regardless of the presence/absence of cP.

Acquiescence Native speakers report that (7B) is somewhat worse than (5) and (6). We attribute this to the fact that, unlike in (5) and (6), the speaker *does* commit in associating the addressee with the property denoted by the imperative in (7B) (cf. Linhares 2025). We tentatively account for the observed variability in (7B) by proposing that acquiescence uses may correspond to either full or cP-less structures. Notably, Portner et al. (2019) propose that the presence of cP is systematically linked to the involvement of a specific interlocutor-addressee.

Implications Among the “weak” imperatives discussed in the literature are IaDs (e.g., ‘Ignore your homework and you will fail this class.’) (von Fintel & Iatridou 2017). We have not been able to test *an* in these cases, as IaDs do not exist in Korean. We believe that pursuing a similar line of inquiry — testing whether clitic-like negation can appear in “weak” imperatives — in other languages may broaden our understanding of imperative representation across different levels and shed light on the articulated structure of the syntax in the treetops (Miyagawa 2022).

Selected References • von Fintel, K. & S. Iatridou. 2017. A modest proposal for the meaning of imperatives. • Han, C.h. 2001. Force, negation and imperatives. • Han, C.h. & C. Lee. 2007. On negative imperatives in Korean. • Linhares, D. 2025. Directives and intentions. • Miyagawa, S. 2022. *Syntax in the treetops*. MIT Press. • Park, J.Y. 2010. A diachronic study on the grammatical status of “malda”. • Portner, P., M. Pak & R. Zanuttini. 2019. The speaker-addressee relation at the syntax-semantics interface. • Zeijlstra, H. 2013. Not in the first place.